

Leadership and City Problems Await Newly-Elected Davao Councilors

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DAVAO CITY, Philippines ? Davao?s City 21st Council is composed of 24 elected councilors where the city?s three districts elect eight councilors.

The new council consists of all members of Duterte?s Hugpong sa Tawong Lungsod party, and a mix of reelectionists, seasoned legislators with long-standing experience, and neophytes who have inherited positions to continue their families? political influence.

Dabawenyos elected four newcomers to the city council: Rodrigo ?Rigo? Duterte II, Ragde Ibuyan, Doce Apostol, and Jopet Baluran. Ibuyan, Apostol, and Baluran all come from political families who have served as city councilors, while Rigo is the grandson of mayor-elect former president Rodrigo Duterte.

There are six returning councilors ? Pamela Librado-Morata, Ralph Abella, Danilo Dayanghirang, Atty. Nonong Cabling, Atty. Petite Principe, and Prosecutor Rachel Zozobrado ? who sat out the previous council after finishing their three-term limits, except for Librado-Morata who withdrew from the 2022 elections.

With this new set of councilors comes the question of who will take the leadership of key committees once they take their oath on June 30, 2025.

Will Councilor-elect Danilo Dayanghirang reclaim leadership over the Finance, Ways and Means, and Appropriations Committee, which plays a vital role in passing the city?s supplemental budget?

Currently, this committee is chaired by reelected Councilor Myrna Dolodo-Ortiz, who successfully passed the city?s ?14-billion budget for 2025.

Before leading the Finance Committee, Ortiz chaired the Women?s Committee, now headed by Councilor Trisha Ann Villafuerte. During Villafuerte?s first term, her committee passed the Solo Parents Ordinance but fell short in introducing significant policies on women?s and children?s programs.

Another closely watched committee is the Labor and Employment Opportunities Committee which may be assumed by Librado-Morata. The committee was previously held by Councilor Bernard Al-ag but was transferred to Councilor Bai Hundra Cassandra Dominique Advincula, following Al-ag?s resignation due to tensions with Mayor Baste.

During her previous tenure as Labor Committee chair, Librado-Morata played a crucial role in supporting food delivery riders? appeal to lower the imposition of city tax fees on their income.

?If given the opportunity, I want to head the Labor Committee again because there is still so much more I can do to continue the service we?ve already been providing,? Librado-Morata said after her proclamation.

Two newly-elected councilors have expressed interest in leading the Social Services Committee, currently chaired by outgoing Councilor Wilberto Al-ag, who lost his congressional bid in the third district.

Councilor-elect Ralph Abella has shown more interest in Al-ag's committee than in continuing the Agriculture, Aquaculture, and Food Committee currently handled by his wife, outgoing Councilor Marissa Abella. Ralph holds the same position in the 19th council.

Meanwhile, Councilor-elect Doce Apostol, a long-time barangay official with experience as a Sanguniang Kabataan chairman, kagawad, and barangay chairman, also aims to secure a role in social services governance. Apostol is the brother of outgoing Councilor Dante Apostol, who served six terms from 2004 to 2025.

Both Abella and Apostol cited their background in barangay governance as an asset in handling social services responsibilities.

Another committee that drew significant attention is the Committee on Environment and Natural Resources. Chaired by first-time Councilor Tek Ocampo, the committee faced challenging issues like the encroachment in Sitio Kalatong watershed, the endorsement of the waste-to-energy project, the Samal Island-Davao City Connector Bridge project, and cutting of trees in urban areas.

Ocampo, now in his second term, has developed a complex relationship with environmental advocates, drawing both support and criticism.

It remains to be seen whether the council will assign newly-elected councilors Ibuyan and Baluran to their fathers' former committees: Government Enterprises and Privatization, Public Works and Highways, and Transportation and Communications.

Looking ahead to the 21st City Council, attention now turns to key leadership assignments. The question is: Who will fill the vacancy in the Education Committee, previously chaired by long-time politician Pilar Braga? During the 20th City Council, Braga sponsored several notable measures, including the establishment of Davao City College, the creation of the Office of Culture and Arts, and the Organ Donation and Transplant Ordinance.

Will Radge Ibuyan assume the chairmanship of the Anti-Terrorism Committee, which was previously headed by his father, Councilor Edgar Ibuyan Sr.? While Radge's background is in finance, he has expressed openness to leading any committee assigned to him, assuring Dabawenyos that he will work hard to fulfill his duties. The Anti-Terrorism Committee was newly created during the 20th Council, despite Davao being declared insurgency-free on May 3, 2022.

Other equally important committees, including the International Relations Committee, formerly led by outgoing Councilor Javi Campos, and the Cooperative Development and People's Participation Committee, previously chaired by outgoing Councilor Jonard Dayap.

Campos played a pivotal role in establishing sisterhood agreements between Davao and various cities in the Philippines and abroad, while Dayap focused on legalizing small community cooperatives.

A key question is who will be the presiding officer because of the detention of mayor-elect Rodrigo Duterte, who stands trial at the International Criminal Court in The Hague, Netherlands.

This would mean Vice Mayor-elect Sebastian "Baste" Duterte may serve as Davao's OIC mayor.

In such a scenario, the councilor with the highest vote count would assume the role of OIC vice mayor ? potentially his nephew, Rigo Duterte II, who garnered 192,324 votes, a significant margin compared to other veteran councilors.

The Comelec Davao office stated after its proclamation on Thursday, May 15, that the final decision now rests with the Department of the Interior and Local Government (DILG).

If the DILG appoints Rigo as OIC Vice Mayor, he would become the youngest official to hold the second-highest position in Davao City at 27, following his uncle Baste.

Relatively new to politics, Rigo stated after his proclamation that he plans to follow in the footsteps of his father, 1st District Representative Paolo, who also served as vice mayor from 2016 to 2017.

?Whatever my father did, I will follow,? he said.

As Davao City transitions into this new leadership, critical questions remain: Will the council address ongoing issues such as traffic congestion, flooding, job opportunities, and public services? Given its role in approving substantial budget allocations for public safety and the mayor?s office, its decisions will significantly shape the city?s future. ? (davaotoday.com)/Rappler.com

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